INTRODUCTION

By far, the biggest budgeting challenge is learning how to spend less. Not just in the little things here and there—we can easily skip buying a latte, cute top, or new throw pillow with some semblance of self-control, but it's also learning how to save on the big things too, like housing payments, utility bills, and those dreaded insurance premiums!

It's quite overwhelming when you start to think about how many things you actually pay for. Every year, it seems my own budget grows larger just to accommodate all the extra things we've added to it. There's always a new subscription service to try, a monthly membership to add, or a brand new décor piece begging you to take it home. But hey, at least we're budgeting for it, right?

The problem is, with all these costs eating up the majority of our income, there's very little left over to put towards something greater down the road. We're sacrificing future opportunities and savings goals in exchange for the most demanding "needs" and "wants" right now. Not to mention the unexpected medical bills and major repairs that happen at the worst time possible.

I can't even begin to tell you how many times we've had a water heater break the same week we replaced the tires on our car, and then on top of that, we find a leak under the sink from a faucet my husband Joseph just repaired. It sends us right back to the starting line, sometimes further behind than when we first began, and yes, it's totally frustrating! Especially when we have a mortgage to pay and food to put on the table on top of everything else.

That's why it's so important to make sure these necessary expenses—the bills you absolutely must pay—are also the least stressful. Because if we don't pay attention to how much we spend on the things we *need*, we'll never make room for the things we actually *want*.

A LIFE-CHANGING PRINCIPLE